encirclement into Bhutan, but most of them died due to the cold and starvation as they had no food or warm clothes or blankets.

Others, like Dalvi's party, wandered around in circles, finding the Chinese already occupying the features they were headed for. Finally, they stumbled into the Chinese just below Hathung-la. Dalvi and the surviving seven members of his party were captured on 22 October. The death struggle of 7 Infantry Brigade would continue as men in small parties and sometimes as individuals continued to battle the elements. Very few made it home.

KHENZEMANE

The Assam Rifles post of Khenzemane was situated on the west bank of the Nyamjang Chu where the river forced its way between the Thagla Ridge and the spur that dropped down from Bum-la. At Khenzemane, C Wing of 5 Assam Rifles under Major H. P. Singh was deployed along the river in the classic arrowhead Indian defensive position—No. 5 Platoon at the head with No. 2 and No. 3 Platoon deployed slightly behind on the flanks. As Khenzemane could be reached by a mule track, unlike the infantry battalions inside the Nam Ka Chu Valley, the Assam Rifles had a fair amount of defensive equipment like barbed wire and entrenching tools that had been put to good effect. Towards the end of September when the build-up in Nam Ka Chu began, Niranjan Prasad had appointed Lieutenant Colonel Rattan Singh, the commanding officer of 5 Assam Rifles, as the Central Sector Commander (Valley Sector) and located Charlie Company of 4 Grenadiers under the command of Second Lieutenant Gopalakrishna Venkatesa Prasanna Rao, in depth around the Drokung Samba Bridge where the track to Zimithang shifted to the east bank.

On 19 October, Niranjan Prasad and Rattan Singh had visited Khenzemane where the Assam Rifles and Grenadiers were also reporting feverish Chinese activity, especially on the Thagla Ridge that overlooked their position on the riverfront. After a while the GOC returned to his Tactical HQ at Zimithang, but in light of the Chinese build-up, Rattan Singh decided to stay on at the Khenzemane post.

At 4 a.m. on 20 October, almost seventy-five minutes before 2 Rajput and 1/9 GR came under fire, the Chinese lit up the night sky over Khenzemane with star shells, illuminating all three Assam Rifles platoons. Within seconds, Chinese mortars and guns opened up. The shelling was not